



Thala ovation: M.S. Dhoni and his teammates take a lap around the M. A. Chidambaram Stadium, acknowledging the roaring Chepauk crowd after CSK's final home game of the IPL 2026 season. PTI

WHERE EVERY DAY BECOMES CONTENT

From packed press rooms to louder-than-life stadiums, our reporters capture the moments, conversations and curiosities **unfolding** beyond the scorecard.

Afternoons in Chennai are not for the weak. But when it comes to M.S. Dhoni and Chennai Super Kings, the city rarely minds the heat.

By 4:30 PM IST, word had already spread that "*Thala*" Dhoni would be at the M. A. Chidambaram Stadium for CSK's clash against Sunrisers Hyderabad. It was the first time this season that the former skipper would visit the ground after being ruled unfit to play

due to recurring injuries. Still, Wallajah Road had already turned yellow, with No. 7 jerseys everywhere.

As the evening settled in, the whistles inside Anbuden only grew louder. Eyes stayed fixed on the Anna Pavilion, waiting for that one moment: Dhoni walking out. It did not happen until the innings break. The floodlights dimmed for the show, and when they came back on, the noise inside the stadium reached another level.

Dhoni stepped out briefly for the team photo, but that was enough. A glimpse of the man was all the 35,000-plus crowd needed.

Even after CSK lost, nobody hurried home. Fans stayed back for the annual lap of honour after the final home game of the season. Dhoni joined his teammates, slowly making his way around the ground, acknowledging a crowd that had waited through a long, hot day to see him once.

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